VIRGINIA

The Old Dominion



Every state has a dish that tells you something true about the people who settled it, and in Virginia that dish just might be a bowl of peanut soup. It is a humble-sounding thing, this soup—made from what was once called the goober, the groundnut, the pindar, a plant so common it was long thought beneath notice. And yet set a bowl of it in front of someone who has never had it, and watch their face change at the first spoonful: creamy, savory, faintly sweet, warmed with the smallest breath of cayenne. It is comfort and elegance in the same bowl, and its story runs as deep as any on the American table.

The peanut did not begin in Virginia. It came the long way, carried across the Atlantic through the trade in enslaved Africans, who knew the groundnut intimately and had cooked with it for generations. They brought that knowledge with them into the kitchens and fields of the coastal South, and it was their hands and their memory that first coaxed the peanut into American cooking. In the sandy, sun-warmed soil of Virginia's Tidewater, the plant found a home and flourished. What had traveled as sustenance for the enslaved became, over time, one of the defining crops of the region—and one of the quiet foundations of its cuisine. To eat Virginia peanut soup is to taste a history that is not always easy, but is always honest: a dish born of hardship and ingenuity, carried forward by the people who made the most of what the land and their circumstances allowed.

For years the peanut stayed close to the ground, both literally and figuratively—food for livestock, food for the poor, food for soldiers who roasted them over campfires and learned to love them. But the humble goober had ambitions. By the time the taverns of the colonial capital at Williamsburg were setting their tables, peanut soup had climbed from field to fine dining. Ground smooth and enriched with cream, seasoned with care and served with a little ceremony, it became the sort of dish a traveler might remember long after the journey home. It still graces those tables today, ladled warm in the taverns around Williamsburg, where it has become as much a part of Virginia's welcome as a candle in the window.

What makes it endure is the same thing that made it in the first place: it does so much with so little. A few spoonfuls of ground peanuts, a good stock, a knob of butter, a whisper of onion and celery, and suddenly there is richness where there was thrift. That is the genius of Southern country cooking in a single bowl—the ability to make plenty out of modesty, to turn the overlooked into the beloved. Finish it with a scatter of chopped peanuts across the top, and the soup reminds you, with every crunch, exactly where it came from: from the red-clay fields and sandy rows of Virginia, from the hands that planted and picked and stirred, from a long line of cooks who believed that even the plainest ingredient deserved to be treated with grace.

So this is Virginia in a bowl—not the grand Virginia of monuments and marble, but the truer Virginia of the harvest and the hearth. It tastes of thrift and plenty at once—a Virginia harvest, ground smooth and served with a little ceremony.

PEANUT SOUP

From the red-clay fields to the tavern table, the taste of a Virginia harvest, ground smooth and served warm.

Yield: 6 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 4 Tbsp unsalted butter
- 1 medium onion, finely chopped
- 2 ribs celery, finely chopped
- 2 Tbsp all-purpose flour
- 4 cups chicken stock
- 1 cup smooth peanut butter (unsweetened, natural if possible)
- 1 cup half-and-half or whole milk
- 1 tsp Worcestershire sauce
- ½ tsp salt, plus more to taste
- ¼ tsp pepper
- ⅛ tsp cayenne pepper (optional)
- ¼ cup roasted peanuts, chopped, for garnish
- 2 Tbsp chopped fresh chives or parsley, for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Soften the aromatics*: In a heavy saucepan or Dutch oven, melt the butter over medium heat. Add the onion and celery and cook, stirring often, until soft and translucent but not browned, 6–8 minutes. Keeping the heat gentle here lets the vegetables sweeten without coloring, which keeps the finished soup pale and delicate.
2. *Make the roux*: Sprinkle the flour over the vegetables and cook, stirring constantly, for 2 minutes to cook out the raw taste. This brief roux is what gives the soup its smooth, velvety body.
3. *Build the base*: Pour in the chicken stock in a slow stream, whisking as you go to keep it lump-free. Bring to a gentle simmer and cook for 5 minutes, until slightly thickened.
4. *Strain for silk*: For the classic tavern-smooth texture, strain the soup through a fine-mesh sieve, pressing on the solids, and return the liquid to the pot. (If you prefer a more rustic bowl, you can skip this and leave the aromatics in.)
5. *Whisk in the peanut butter*: Reduce the heat to low. Add the peanut butter a spoonful at a time, whisking until each addition melts completely into the broth before adding the next. Take your time—adding it gradually is the key to a smooth soup that won't turn oily or grainy.
6. *Finish and season*: Stir in the half-and-half, Worcestershire, salt, black pepper, and cayenne. Warm gently over low heat until steaming, but do not let it boil, or the dairy may separate. Taste and adjust the salt.
7. *Serve*: Ladle into warm bowls and finish each with a scatter of chopped peanuts and a pinch of chives or parsley. Serve hot, with the peanuts added at the last moment so they keep their crunch.

